

Chapter 128_1 - Growing Feelings

Those eyes were extremely beautiful, even while situated in the midst of scorched filth they sparkled brightly, like a clear lake at dawn, shrouded in misty vapors.

She seemed unwilling to let others see her in this state. Her fingertips trembled lightly, conjuring white mist several times, but for some unknown reason her immortal power was dim, or perhaps she was severely injured—she couldn't even materialize a cloth to cover herself.

"Get lost quickly," she finally spoke, her voice hoarse.

"If you don't tell me what this cursed place is, how can I get lost!" Seeing her so weak, Ning Fuyi squatted down and called out loudly, "Where is this, and who are you?"

The woman seemed unwilling to answer her words, instead her fingertips trembled as she struggled several times to take out a snow-white garment from that bead, laboriously trying to cover her bare limbs.

She was indeed a respectable person. Ning Fuyi looked down at her for a while, then finally raised her hand, and demonic energy surged into her surroundings. When it dispersed, the clothing was already neat and tidy, and the scorched hair had become smooth as before, though the wounds on her body could not be removed.

Indeed, it was the Heavenly Dao's¹ punishment—wounds that could not be healed with immortal power. Ning Fuyi's eyes turned thoughtfully.

The woman, now covered, seemed somewhat calmer in her emotions. Her movements were extremely slow as she got up, seemingly pulled by pain and not daring to use force.

However, she never raised her head, so Ning Fuyi couldn't see her face clearly despite watching for a long time.

"You're a cultivator, aren't you? And it seems you cultivate the righteous path. Why is it that seeing my demonic energy, you show not half a bit of surprise?" Ning Fuyi's interest grew even stronger, so she slid down with one hand supporting herself, standing beside the woman and reaching out to lift her hair.

"Stop!" The woman suddenly retreated a step, her shoulders trembling in pain, but her head remained lowered as she bit her teeth and said, "What are you here for?"

Seeing her so guarded, Ning Fuyi found it even stranger, but she didn't press too hard and withdrew her arm.

"It's not like I wanted to come to this cursed place—it was those damned heavenly thunders that struck me here." Ning Fuyi lazily arranged her hem. "You still haven't told me where this is? How is it that I can't sense even a trace of human presence?"

The woman was silent for a long while before finally saying in a low voice: "This is the Primordial Chaos². Those who violate the Heavenly Dao fall into this place, and every few days they are punished by heavenly thunder."

"Primordial Chaos?" Ning Fuyi raised her dark eyebrows slightly, the two black moles under her eyes becoming even more prominent as she leaned closer. "Did you kill and commit arson?"

"I did not."

"Then did you cultivate evil arts?"

"I did not."

"Then what kind of heaven-defying crime did you commit that even I, a demon lord, haven't received such punishment, yet you have to endure it?" Ning Fuyi touched her Emei Thorn³ and sneered.

Taking advantage of the woman's evasion, she suddenly straightened up and moved forward, her palm wind blowing away the woman's hair. The woman was greatly startled and hurriedly turned to dodge, but Ning Fuyi moved extremely fast, raising her hand to clamp down on her neck, forcing her to look up at herself.

Like the heavenly thunder from before striking her head, Ning Fuyi froze from head to toe, immediately stunned in place.

The neck in her palm was smooth and delicate, with even bones and flesh. The beautiful face was forcibly exposed under the heavenly light, skin smooth as egg white, with a scarlet scar extending into her hair, etched in the pupils of the beholder, impossible to forget.

The woman's expression was cold, only her eyes revealing a hint of humiliation and anger. She struggled to break free, but finally let her hand drop powerlessly.

"Now that you've seen clearly who I am, you can let go," she said.

Ning Fuyi had not yet recovered from her shock. Only when the shock faded did years of disgust and resentment surge up in her heart. She immediately darkened her expression and tightened her five fingers.

"Chu Qingqiu," she said, half complex, half playful.

Seeing her expression, Chu Qingqiu naturally knew she could not escape this calamity. But how could the proud spirit of her lifetime be easily severed? So she struggled to take out white bone, gripping it tightly in her palm, red lips parting lightly to spit out two cold words: "Evil obstacle⁴, let go."

"How dare you still say that!" Ning Fuyi's anger, suppressed for many years, exploded in an instant because of these words "evil obstacle." Her grip tightened, choking the already wounded woman until her face turned red.

At the same time, her other hand gripped the Emei Thorn tightly, staring intently at the woman's throat, as if wanting to pierce through that layer of soft white skin to see the bright red blood flow.

However, just as the two were in a standoff, muffled thunder suddenly came from overhead again. Ning Fuyi had just raised her eyelids when she saw a blinding lightning bolt break through the clouds and descend, about to fall into the pit.

Chu Qingqiu naturally heard the commotion, so she closed her eyes and prepared to endure it. Who would have thought that despite the thunderous sound that nearly shattered her eardrums echoing through heaven and earth, she felt no pain. Instead, she was released from the restraint on her neck, her whole body rising with the fierce wind, then crashing into a warm embrace.

Even she was momentarily stunned, then heard muffled thunder again. Her waist tightened as if someone had embraced her, carrying her away from the original spot through the air.

Unlike the fierce wind, a gentle breeze lifted the hair by her ears. Behind her came an unpleasant curse from behind, seeming to curse both the heavenly thunder and herself.

Chu Qingqiu opened her eyes. In the rumbling thunder, she clearly heard the heartbeat of the woman behind her, pressed against her back, each beat distinct.

She fell into subtle shock.

However, heavenly thunder was not so easily appeased. Like a net covering heaven and earth, it struck down relentlessly. Ning Fuyi could only carry her as they fled left and right, black and white garments entangled together, constantly fluttering in the fierce wind, almost becoming two streams of contrasting light.

"This is the Heavenly Dao's punishment—it cannot be avoided," Chu Qingqiu finally spoke calmly, as if pain was nothing, as if the one to be punished was not herself.

At this moment her clothes were disheveled and she was quite embarrassed. Yet when these words came out, Ning Fuyi suddenly held her waist and back completely in her arms. Chu Qingqiu was caught off guard and her face crashed into her thin but strong shoulder.

The woman's exotic fragrance rushed into her nostrils, making Chu Qingqiu momentarily dazed.

"I refuse to believe this broken Heavenly Dao has so much thunder that it can strike until the end of time!" Ning Fuyi lost her temper at the sky, raising her hand to summon rolling thunder and lightning. For a moment, the electric light almost burned the entire heaven and earth, directly blasting the green grassy ground into a wasteland.

Finally, after who knows how long—long enough that not a single patch of good ground could be seen on the plain—the startling thunder overhead finally ceased. Strong winds swept away the dark clouds, and Ning Fuyi loosened her arms, throwing the woman in her embrace under a surviving withered tree.

Then she rolled over herself and sat in the dirt, gasping for breath.

Chu Qingqiu weakly propped up her body. The wind brushed away her disheveled hair, her thin lips slightly pursed as she spoke with indifference: "It's none of your business—why did you interfere?"

Ning Fuyi had just wiped away some sweat when she heard these cold words, immediately reigniting her anger. She sat cross-legged looking at her, sneering: "Worthy of being a Divine Venerable⁵—even when a tiger falls to the plains, you're still high and mighty."

"For many years I've had a question lingering in my heart: exactly what did I do to wrong you that's worth you treating me this way time and again?"

Chu Qingqiu's eyes hidden under her eyelashes showed changing emotions. After a long time, she said: "You did nothing wrong. However, eliminating demons and exterminating evil is my duty. As a demon that brings disaster to the world, my not killing you already follows my promise to Ning Changfeng⁶."

"You won't kill me?" Ning Fuyi laughed bitterly at herself. She suddenly flashed to Chu Qingqiu's front, reaching out to pin her against the tree again, causing withered leaves to fall.

"Then before I became a demon, what did you do? When the world repeatedly oppressed and bullied me, killed my loved ones, no one protected me before I became a demon. But when I cultivated the demonic path to protect myself, you wanted to eliminate me. All the good words have been taken by you!"

"Now open your eyes and see—who really spared whom!" Her words were 激愤, and the tear moles under her eyes became even more alluring.

Chu Qingqiu didn't look at her, as if she disdained to look, her eyes still downcast, making Ning Fuyi press harder, almost lifting her up against the tree trunk.

Chu Qingqiu's perfectly outlined chin was raised high, suffocation making the corners of her eyes red as poppies, but she shed not a single tear.

Ning Fuyi held the standoff for a while, then suddenly released her hand, her trembling fingertips withdrawing into her sleeves, placed behind her back. Her phoenix eyes slightly closed, then opened again with vicious color.

"I won't kill you," she turned around. "Anyway, I can't get out of this chaos now, so I'll stay and watch closely—watch how you're tormented by the Heavenly Dao you so revere!"

Behind her, Chu Qingqiu slowly slid down, finally half-kneeling on the ground, hair sliding down her shoulders as she gently closed her eyes.

Though harsh words were spoken, in the following days, the two of them actually became strangely peaceful.

Human relationships are quite wonderful—even if two people are incompatible like fire and water, when they are the only two people in a world, like two sheep待宰 in a pen, even if they repel each other, they will develop a familiarity between kindred spirits.

Ning Fuyi didn't know what Chu Qingqiu thought, but she was like this. Though the two kept far apart, she often paid attention to that bamboo house on the other side of the slope. Every time she opened her eyes, she would extend her divine consciousness to observe for a while.

But the woman always seemed dead, without half a bit of movement.

Heavenly thunder didn't come every day. When there was no punishment, the Primordial Chaos was like a paradise outside the world—quiet and serene, with high sky and broad earth, no other life besides them.

Ning Fuyi had tried to split open the chaos, but though she had stumbled in by accident, she couldn't break out no matter how she tried. After many unsuccessful attempts, fortunately she had always detested the chaotic human world, so she wasn't urgent about it.

The only inconvenience was that this Primordial Chaos would weaken one's demonic energy. Though she wasn't like Chu Qingqiu who had almost all her immortal power sealed away, it still had an effect on her.

Besides this, being in this boundless paradise, breathing the mountain and field breezes daily, the violent demonic energy in her heart gradually faded away, and her thoughts became much calmer than before.

Occasionally witnessing flower buds blooming, her heart would soften, as if returning to that self before entering the demonic path who had never been stained with blood.

On this day, Ning Fuyi was transplanting those wild flowers to one place, preparing to make a small flower garden, when she suddenly heard hammering sounds in the wind, so she flew over to look.

The sound came from the other side of the slope. The originally intact bamboo house roof had a hole cracked in it, probably caused by wind and rain. A figure was climbing onto the roof with straw in hand, trying to repair the broken house.

Ning Fuyi, dressed in brilliant black, floated in mid-air with her hands behind her waist, frowning as she watched.

Chu Qingqiu had most of her immortal power sealed by the Heavenly Dao, so she mostly used hands and feet for daily tasks. Ning Fuyi had been enthusiastically spying these past few days and had glimpsed some of this.

"After all these years apart, the Divine Venerable's skills have also greatly improved—now you've even learned to climb walls and repair roofs."

Chu Qingqiu was silently laying straw when a mocking voice suddenly came from behind her. Her movements paused, but she wasn't affected and continued looking down to repair.

Her expression was calm, making the roof repair task seem elegant and noble. Ning Fuyi watched for a long while with hands on her hips but couldn't see her embarrassment, feeling slightly disappointed.

However, as Ning Fuyi watched, she noticed something wrong. The originally clear heavenly light gradually became turbid, and a few withered leaves were swept past her ears by the wind, making rustling sounds.

Not good—heavenly thunder was coming again!

She immediately leaned back and retreated, her hair and black garments sweeping past her eyes like black mist, instantly leaving several zhang away. Though her body left, her gaze remained on that graceful figure.

Chu Qingqiu finally used her immortal power at this time, transforming into flowing light wanting to cross the slope. However, this time the heavenly thunder came fiercely. With just one loud boom, flying sand and stones blinded one's eyes.

Ning Fuyi hurriedly raised her sleeve to cover her face, the sand hitting her sleeve with intense crackling sounds.

She swept it away and looked carefully—the woman had ultimately not escaped the heavenly thunder and was now struck down to the ground, her slender body curled into a ball.

Ning Fuyi's gracefully departing figure stopped, frowning as she stared intently.

Watching the second heavenly thunder strike down, the woman initially still struggled to dodge, but later could only compromise, lying motionless. Occasionally rolling a couple times was only because the fierce wind had blown her form away.

Dark clouds overhead still bore thunder and lightning, from time to time splitting the sky in half. Seeing her lying motionless as if lifeless, Ning Fuyi finally couldn't bear it and cursed, stepping on black energy to flash away, brushing past another falling heavenly thunder to snatch her up, holding her around the waist.

The body in her arms had already gone soft and cold. Ning Fuyi spun to avoid the relentlessly pursuing light balls while rushing toward distant mountains, one hand checking Chu Qingqiu's pulse.

Fortunately the person wasn't dead, just temporarily unconscious.

She flew until she had almost exhausted her demonic energy, then could only carry the woman running through the mountains, cursing at the sky as she ran, swearing at eight generations of the Heavenly Dao's ancestors.

Finally, after the heavenly thunder had leveled who knows how many mountain peaks behind them, the rumbling overhead finally dissipated. Ning Fuyi, drenched in sweat, knelt on the ground and picked up a blade of green grass, sticking it into Chu Qingqiu's ear to poke her.

Only then did Chu Qingqiu open her eyes. The moment she saw Ning Fuyi, she instinctively summoned white bone to swing at her, fortunately Ning Fuyi was quick-eyed and grabbed both her wrists.

"Chu Qingqiu, you're repaying kindness with enmity!" she scolded, still shaken.

"What kindness..." Chu Qingqiu's words stopped halfway. Her eyes swept over the woman's face full of sweat, then swept toward the devastated mountains and rivers behind her. Her hand involuntarily softened, and the white bone scattered into flying feathers.

Confusion flashed in her peach blossom eyes. Upon discovering she was still lying in Ning Fuyi's arms, she hurriedly struggled to withdraw. Her originally calm heart lake was like having a stone thrown into it, ripples gradually rising.

"Wasn't the plan to watch how I'd be tormented? Why interfere again?" Chu Qingqiu turned her face away, enduring pain as she spoke in a low voice.

"Who knows?" Ning Fuyi stared at her, phoenix eyes showing shadows. "Perhaps I discovered I don't hate you as much as I imagined."

"Just a pitiful creature without feeling or love—not worth me spending great effort to take your life."

Footnotes:

¹ **Heavenly Dao (天道)** - The Way of Heaven, representing the natural order and laws that govern the universe in Chinese philosophy and cultivation fiction

² **Primordial Chaos (混沌之初)** - The state of the universe before creation, a place of punishment in this cultivation world

³ **Emei Thorn (峨眉刺)** - A weapon resembling a hairpin with sharp points, traditionally associated with the Emei martial arts school

⁴ **Evil Obstacle (孽障)** - A derogatory term meaning an evil being or calamity, often used to scold someone severely

⁵ **Divine Venerable (神尊)** - A high-ranking title in cultivation novels, indicating someone who has reached near-godlike status

⁶ **Ning Changfeng (宁长风)** - Ning Fuyi's mother, as referenced in the story context